reward that individual if he got my child back. That's not paying ransom to the kidnappers."

Because of the opposition of Cap and George, I decided to wait. The Pearl Harbor Day meeting ended without me making a decision, although I said I wanted to keep the channels open and asked Bud McFarlane to take the next step and meet again with the principals involved in the negotiations. I told him to say we wanted a dialogue directly with responsible Iranians, and that the Iranians could prove they were responsible by freeing the hostages, but that we would not trade arms for hostages.

When he returned later that month from a meeting with the group in London, Bud told me that they had demanded shipments of additional weapons and had said that if word leaked out about the negotiations and our refusal to send arms, the lives of Iranian moderates involved in the contacts, as well as those of the hostages, would be in jeopardy. Bud said he thought that Ghorbanifar, an expatriate Iranian arms merchant who was the principal middle man in the negotiations, was untrustworthy, and he was blunt in expressing his misgivings about continuing the initiative.

But I felt that there were not many other options—possibly there were no others—open to us for getting the hostages home. I believed we had to explore every road, to do everything we could to get them out of Beirut as well as to develop a relationship with the future leaders of Iran. Despite difficulties, I believed that this group offered the best hope for accomplishing both objectives.

Although I didn't make a decision at that meeting on Pearl Harbor Day, inside I felt that we should proceed with the initiative on a step-by-step basis—cautiously and in compliance with the law—to see where it would lead. As I've said, I felt a heavy weight on my shoulders to get the hostages home. We were coming up to another Christmas